

Is it audible?

Audible.com is now available as a Blackberry application. The app lets you shop, sample, download, and playback audio from Audible's catalog. The application is free, and it's compatible with the Blackberry Storm, Bold, Curve 83xx, Pearl and 8800

phones. The handsfree unit also falls short of what we term as excellent but it's fair enough. The handset itself is very usable but feature shy. The price, Rs. 61,589 comes as a shock, but not to those familiar with the ethos of Nokia's 8800 series that signify true signature handsets, each created with a purpose and intent of their own, and each unique in some ways and inspired by sapphires, diamonds and gold. We feel that such luxuries aren't worth indulging in – after all a cellphone is a cellphone. It would be much better to spend a lakh or so on an Omega watch rather than on this phone. However there will be those who disagree and want something that allows them to take calls and flaunt wealth at the same time. If you fit the bill, be prepared to reach for your cheque book.

Apple iPhone 3G

Apple's design sense has always been splendid; the iPhone 3G doesn't break that rule. The first time you look at it; you'll think iPod Touch on a high-fat diet. Thankfully the rear resists normal smudging and scratches. It's not a very thick device but feels large to hold; although with a 3.5-inch screen this isn't exactly a design flaw. Build quality is excellent. Quality of buttons and switches on the device are top-class. The buttons on the sides, top and the headphone jack are chromed and along with the black bezel and chrome trim this adds further visual appeal. Apple's menu system is excellent with the single *Home* button being perfectly functional; most phones with extra keys look Jurassic in comparison.

And we're not kidding; the 3G's appeal lies in its blatantly simple and usable



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interface and the sheer joy and funkiness of a touch and finger swipe navigation system that works flawlessly. Once you use the Touch or the iPhone you'll realise the countless lookalikes these devices have spawned are light years away from the real thing. The phone's proximity sensor and low-light sensor work flawlessly.

The iPhone menus work well, but the on-screen keypad is a little small and you will make a few incorrect key taps for the first month or so, which won't please SMS junkies. The phone's number pad is huge though; and you'll have to be a clod to goof up typing out numbers. There is no way to delete or select multiple messages. You also cannot save a typed out SMS as a draft. Given the problem with the cramped keypad we'd have thought a Bluetooth keyboard would help but Apple chose to cut us short; the iPhone's Bluetooth only works with headsets and not with other devices. File transfer over Bluetooth is also missed.

In terms of signal quality we found the iPhone to be lacking when we put it through its paces in comparison to other phones. It's way behind some of the Nokias and behind some of the other phones too. The loudspeaker also distorts a lot. Thankfully the handsfree unit is as excellent as we've seen and really gets one through many calls where the signal quality is not as good thanks to its high volume level and exceptional clarity. Music quality on headphones is also superb.

It has a lot of niggles to work through as well as some features that it badly needs, but the iPhone 3G is a stylish device. Priced at Rs. 35,000 from operators such as Vodafone and Airtel, it's not a phone for everyone. But those who succumb to its charms are sure to become fans.

Nokia N95 8 GB

The N95 has a rubber finish, which in itself isn't of very high quality. However, the plastics used for the rest of the body are and the N95 8 GB lasts through a fair bit of abuse. It's a decent looking phone and the matte finish gives it a serious, suave air, a lot different from the flashy 6-Series phones Nokia currently makes. It's a thick, clunky phone dominated by a wonderfully rich and crisp display that at 2.8-inches supports 24-bit colour depth.

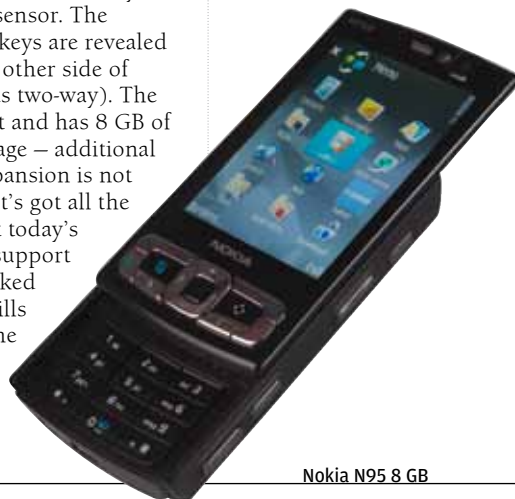
Below the screen is a very PDA-like chrome ring of buttons. The menu and call buttons are cleverly placed on this ring and while everything looks a little intimidating a couple of hours of use and one learns to appreciate the thought behind the layout. The joypad is well laid out and all the keys on the front fascia offer good feedback. The backlight used is superb and very visible. The phone's slider mechanism, while slick at first, does develop some play as mechanics cause looseness with time. The revealed number keypad is well laid out and the keys are beveled with just the right amount of travel and feedback. Backlighting is superb and so is the functionality of the light sensor. The multimedia keys are revealed beneath the other side of the slider (its two-way). The phone is fast and has 8 GB of in-built storage – additional memory expansion is not supported. It's got all the features that today's cellphones support – Nokia packed this to the gills and about the only thing missing is a QWERTY keypad.

The N95 8 GB has a superb antenna and calls are crystal clear with great reception wherever you go. It trounced even the N96 in zone 1 and the earpiece volume and handsfree clarity is top notch. The headset is also suitable for music and MP3s sound great on this phone and in

conjunction with the eight gigabytes of storage built in, the N95 8GB can double as an MP3 player.

With a 1200 mAh battery the N95 8GB will go for at least

five and a half hours while talking on GSM networks. Its five megapixel camera is no slouch and with a few tweaked settings, the N95 8 GB can really hold its own except with the newer, more advanced Samsung cameras. It's an older phone now, but still offers all the goods, now at a lower price. For Rs. 28,389 the N95 8 GB is nearly Rs. 10,000 cheaper than the N96 which is not always a better phone but offers a couple of extra features and greater storage. With prices as low as Rs. 24,000 on the street, now may be the right time to grab this handset; if you can live with its mediocre finish and its chunky looks.



Nokia N95 8 GB